The Maya

Study guide · Social Studies · Ancient Mesoamerica

BIG QUESTION

Why would a culture believe that humans were made of corn?

The **Popol Vuh** is the sacred book of the K'iche' Maya. Its name means roughly "Book of the Community" or "Book of the People" (*vuh* means "book"). In its creation story, the gods first try to make people out of mud, then out of wood, and both fail. Finally they shape people out of **maize (corn) dough**, and it works.

Why corn? Because maize was the center of Maya life: it was their main food, farming followed its seasons, and their religion had a maize god. A people whose whole world depended on corn told a story in which they were made of it.

📍 Where did they live?

The Maya lived in **southern Mexico** (the Yucatán Peninsula and Chiapas) and **northern Central America**: **Guatemala, Belize**, and parts of **Honduras** and **El Salvador**. Their land had three main regions:

Region	What it's like	Famous cities
Northern Lowlands	Flat, dry limestone land on the Yucatán Peninsula (Mexico)	Chichén Itzá, Uxmal, Edzná, Mayapán
Southern Lowlands	Hot, rainy tropical forest	Tikal (Guatemala), Palenque (Mexico), Copán (Honduras), Calakmul (Mexico)
Highlands	Cool mountains and volcanoes in the far south	Kaminaljuyú (Guatemala)

⏳ When did they live?

Period	Dates (about)	What happened
Preclassic	2000 BC – AD 250	Farming villages grow into the first cities and pyramids.
Classic	AD 250 – 900	The "golden age." Great cities like Tikal, Palenque and Copán are ruled by kings.
Postclassic	AD 900 – 1524	Power moves north to cities like Chichén Itzá and later Mayapán. The Spanish arrive in the 1500s.

💡 Different textbooks round these dates a little differently. Pick one set and stick with it.

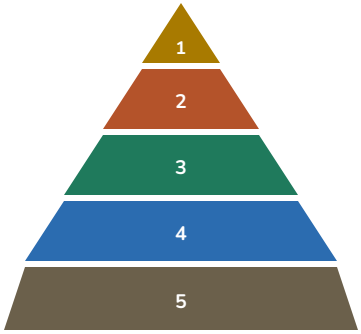
🌽 Food, farming and trade

Main crops: **maize**, **beans** and **squash**, plus chili peppers and **cacao** (the bean chocolate comes from).

Slash-and-burn farming: farmers cut down a patch of forest, burned it, and planted in the ashes, which made the soil richer. After a few years the soil wore out, so they moved to a new patch. They also built **terraces** on hillsides and **raised fields** in swampy land.

Trade: Kings and merchants traded goods like salt, jade, obsidian (volcanic glass for tools), feathers and cotton cloth. Cacao beans were so valuable they were sometimes used like money.

👑 Social organization



1. **The king**: called the “holy lord.” People believed he was connected to the gods. He led in war, religion and trade.
2. **Nobles and priests**: royal family, officials, scribes and priests who led ceremonies and kept the calendars.
3. **Merchants and artisans**: traders, potters, sculptors, weavers and builders.
4. **Farmers and workers**: **most** Maya people. They grew food, paid tribute and helped build temples.
5. **Enslaved people**: often prisoners captured in war, or people being punished for crimes.

🛕 Religion and calendars

The Maya worshipped **many gods** connected to nature, like **Chaak** (god of rain), **Itzamnaaj** (a creator god) and the **Maize God**. They built tall **pyramid-temples**, held ceremonies and offerings, and played a sacred **ballgame**.

Tzolk'in: 260 days

13 numbers × 20 day names. This was the **sacred calendar** used to plan ceremonies. A person's birthday on the Tzolk'in was believed to shape their life and was often part of their name.

Haab': 365 days

18 months of 20 days, plus 5 extra days thought to be unlucky. This **solar calendar** followed the seasons and the farming year.

💡 The two calendars ran together like gears. The same combination of dates came back only once every **52 years**.

✍️ Writing, numbers and science

The Maya had the most complete **writing system** in the ancient Americas. Their **hieroglyphs** mixed signs for whole words with signs for syllables. They carved them on stone monuments and painted them in folding books called **codices**.

Diego de Landa was a Spanish Franciscan friar in Yucatán (he later became its bishop). In **1562**, in the town of Maní, he burned many Maya books because he saw them as against his religion; only **four** codices survive today. Later he wrote a book about the Maya that included a **“Maya alphabet.”** His alphabet was mistaken (Maya writing isn't an alphabet), but in 1952 the Russian scholar **Yuri Knorozov** used it as a key to show that many glyphs stand for sounds. That helped people start reading Maya writing again.

The Maya counted in **20s** and were one of the first peoples to use **zero**. They tracked the Sun, Moon and Venus very accurately.



0 = shell 1 = dot 5 = bar 7 = 2 dots + bar

📉 Decline, and the Maya today

- Between about **AD 800 and 900**, people left most of the big southern cities. Historians think several causes worked together: long **droughts**, **too many people** for the land, **cutting down forests**, and **wars** between cities.
- The Maya did **not** disappear. Northern cities like Chichén Itzá kept going.
- The **Spanish conquest** began in the 1500s. The last independent Maya kingdom fell in **1697**.
- **Today**, millions of Maya people live in Mexico, Guatemala, Belize, Honduras and El Salvador, and speak about 30 Mayan languages.

⚠️ Watch out for these mix-ups

- **Popol Vuh** is the name of a book. *Vuh* means “book,” not “corn.” The corn is in the *story*.
- **Tikal, Palenque and Copán** are rainforest cities of the **southern lowlands**, not the highlands.
- **Tzolk'in (260)** = sacred calendar for ceremonies and birthdays. **Haab' (365)** = solar calendar for seasons and farming.
- Spelling: **highlands**, **lowlands**, **slash-and-burn farming**, **priests**, **nobles**.

✅ Check yourself

1. Name the five countries where the Maya lived.
2. Put the periods in order and give rough dates: Classic, Postclassic, Preclassic.
3. Explain slash-and-burn farming in two sentences. Why did farmers have to keep moving?
4. Which group was at the top of the social pyramid? Which group had the most people?
5. What is the difference between the Tzolk'in and the Haab'?
6. Give two possible reasons why the southern Maya cities were abandoned.

Show answers

1. Mexico, Guatemala, Belize, Honduras and El Salvador.
2. Preclassic (2000 BC – AD 250) → Classic (AD 250 – 900) → Postclassic (AD 900 – 1524).
3. Farmers cut and burned a patch of forest, then planted in the ash-rich soil. After a few years the soil wore out, so they cleared a new patch.
4. The king was at the top. Farmers and workers were the largest group.
5. The Tzolk'in has 260 days and was used for ceremonies and birthdays. The Haab' has 365 days and followed the seasons.
6. Any two: drought, too many people, deforestation, war between cities.